

RESOURCE 10 · BEHAVIORAL

SOAR: Stories That Land

Spend more time on the obstacle and the actions than on the context, and your behavioral answers stop wandering.

TIME ALLOCATION FOR A 2-MINUTE BEHAVIORAL ANSWER



SITUATION	OBSTACLES	ACTIONS	RESULTS
The context. One or two sentences. Project, your role, what the team was trying to do. <i>Common mistake: spending half the answer here.</i> 12% of time	What made this hard. The interesting part. What was at stake, unknown, contested. Constraints, conflict. <i>Common mistake: skipping this entirely and rushing to action.</i> 25% of time	What you did. Use "I," not "we." Decisions, conversations, tradeoffs. Specifics. <i>The largest budget. This is what the interviewer evaluates.</i> 50% of time	What happened. Quantify when possible. Business impact, technical outcome, customer effect. <i>Common mistake: burying the outcome under more context.</i> 13% of time

BUILD A LIBRARY OF 5-10 STORIES COVERING:

- Leading without authority
- Handling conflict
- A tough technical tradeoff
- Owning ambiguity
- Prioritizing under pressure
- Failing and learning
- Mentoring or unblocking someone
- Pushing back on a decision
- Cross-team collaboration

RESOURCE 10 · BEHAVIORAL · EXAMPLES

Three SOAR stories in full

LEADING WITHOUT AUTHORITY

The API contract nobody could agree on.

- S** **SITUATION**
I was a senior IC on a four-person backend team rebuilding the billing API. No tech lead on the team.
- O** **OBSTACLES**
Our manager left mid-quarter. Three engineers, three different proposals for the contract. PM was waiting on a decision to plan downstream work. Six weeks until the deadline and nobody had authority to call it.
- A** **ACTIONS**
I set up a daily 20-minute sync. Built a decision matrix with five axes: latency, schema flexibility, migration cost, blast radius, and team familiarity. Walked through it in a doc, named my pick, and asked for written disagreement by Friday. When two engineers pushed back, I rewrote the matrix with their inputs and re-shared. I also volunteered to write the integration tests so they could keep moving.
- R** **RESULTS**
Shipped on time. The contract has held through three follow-on features. I was promoted that cycle, and the matrix template is still in our team doc.

FAILING AND LEARNING

The migration that almost cost us \$30K a day.

- S** **SITUATION**
I led the migration of our payment service to a new processor.
- O** **OBSTACLES**
I underestimated the reconciliation work. In week one of the rollout, finance flagged a daily delta of around \$30K that we couldn't explain. The CFO wanted to roll back; I had two days to prove we shouldn't.
- A** **ACTIONS**
I paused new traffic at 10%. Ran a three-day audit with one engineer and one finance analyst. Found a missing field in the mapping for partial refunds. Wrote a backfill script, paired with finance to verify it against three months of history, and built a pre-flight check that compares end-to-end ledgers before any future cutover.
- R** **RESULTS**
Caught the bug before full rollout. Wrote the postmortem; the pre-flight check is now standard on every migration my team runs.

PUSHING BACK ON A DECISION

When the VP wanted to skip the load test.

- S** **SITUATION**
We were two weeks from launching a new onboarding flow expected to triple sign-up traffic.
- O** **OBSTACLES**
The VP wanted to cut the load test to hit the date. I disagreed, but I was the most junior engineer in the room and our staff engineer had stayed quiet.
- A** **ACTIONS**
I put the risk in dollars: \$40K per hour of downtime, 35% chance of a capacity issue. Proposed a four-hour pared-down test instead of the two-day one. Sent it in writing, copied the staff engineer.
- R** **RESULTS**
Surfaced two queue-depth issues we'd have hit in production. Launch was clean. Load tests are now standard.